town,' remembered Captain Thomas Seaton. 'The terrible wailing sound of those bugles I will never forget. It was a dirge for our slaughtered soldiers and, heard all through the night, it had an inexpressibly mournful and depressing effect. Dr Brydon's tale struck horror into the hearts of all who heard it . . . The whole army had been destroyed, one man alone escaping to tell the fearful tale.'[65]

In the days that followed, a few other survivors limped in, including Dr Brydon's friend Mr Banness, the Greek merchant, and several hardy Gurkhas. In time the legend grew that the entire British army in Afghanistan had been wiped out. This of course was not the case: large garrisons survived in Kandahar and Jalalabad, and even of the Kabul army there were 2,000 sepoys who ultimately came home along with thirty-five British officers, fifty-one private soldiers, twelve wives and twenty-two children, all of whom were either taken hostage (in the case of the Europeans) or managed to stumble back to Kabul to beg on the streets (in the case of the Hindustanis). It was nonetheless an extraordinary defeat for the British and an almost miraculous victory for the Afghan resistance. At the very height of the British Empire, at a point when the British controlled more of the world economy than they would ever do again, and at a time when traditional forces were everywhere being massacred by industrialised colonial armies, it was a rare moment of complete colonial humiliation.

The story was immediately retold by Afghan poets and singers, the numbers of casualties and the scale of the victory growing with each retelling. 'It is said that 60,000 English troops – half from Bengal, half from other provinces, without counting servants and camp-followers – went to Afghanistan,' wrote Mirza 'Ata,

> and only a handful came back alive, wounded and destitute. The rest fell with neither grave nor shroud to cover them, and lay scattered in that land like rotting donkeys. The English love gold and money so much that they cannot stop themselves from laying their hands on any area productive of wealth. But what prize did they find in Afghanistan except, on the one hand, the exhausting of their treasury and, on the other, the disgracing of their army? It is said that of the 40,000 English troops who had been in Kabul, many were taken captive en route, many remained as cripples and beggars in Kabul, and the rest perished in the mountains, like a ship sunk without trace; for it is no easy thing to invade or govern the Kingdom of Khurasan.[66]